defeat of the Ghaznavid Sultan Mas'ud I (r. 1030–1041 CE) at Dandanqan by Saljuq ibn Duqaq's grandsons Tughril (r. AH 431–455/1040–1063 CE) and Chagri (AH 432–452/1040–1060 CE) meant that various constellations of their descendants held sway across central–western Eurasia – initiating prosperity as well as abundant building that would help define the architectural cultures of Iran and Central Asia until the Mongol incursions.

To their great advantage, the Saljuqs also inherited a sophisticated politico-cultural landscape: it was replete with centuries of accreted administrative infrastructure thanks to the multiple pre-Islamic imperial formations that had spanned western–central Eurasia.[34] Only the most recent among these had been the Sasanians (third–seventh centuries CE), whose "professionalization of a literate administrative class and the culture of the court … were elaborations of what had gone before,"[35] and in turn were developed further according to the changing requirements of ever-burgeoning elites during the eighth through eleventh centuries. To be sure, the Saljuq sultans were notable patrons of architecture, but their works were particularly aligned with proclaiming their Islamic confessionalism (cf. below), with palace architecture serving very punctual functions.[36] In addition to the sultans, the upper echelons of military, political, and scribal personnel throughout the empire – part of the Saljuqs' inherited administrative infrastructure – were also patrons to a significant degree.

The city of Isfahan had held geographical, strategic, and economic significance at least since Sasanian times, becoming a centrally administered city – akin to a regional capital – for the Saljuqs in AH 443/1051 CE. It boasted a major *masjid-i jami* (congregational mosque) as of the mid-ninth century, which would undergo expansion, renovation, and even reconfiguration through the Safavid period.[37] Given the city's local and transregional importance, Saljuq rulers and their courtiers continued to patronize architecture and institutions throughout the city to maintain its prosperity. Approaching our period of investigation, we should highlight the interventions in Isfahan's overall fabric during the late eleventh–twelfth centuries, when major architectural projects attested to the vast array of personages and impetuses underlying this patronage.

Sultan Malik Shah (r. AH 464–485/1072–1092 CE) directed his famous *vazir* Nizam al-Mulk (AH 409–485/1018–1092 CE) to construct the Isfahan *jami*'s south dome *c*. AH 479–480/1086–1087 CE (Figures 1.1 and 1.2), possibly in response to the new dome upon Damascus's Umayyad mosque, commissioned by the *vazir* Abu Nasir Ahmad ibn Fadl in AH 475/1082 CE after a fire. In turn, Nizam al-Mulk's much younger political rival Taj al-Mulk engaged in dangerous intrigue with the elder statesman to win favor with the sultan, in part by commissioning a smaller but "in many ways … aesthetically more successful" northern dome within the already magnificent mosque (Figures 1.1 and 1.3). Not long after, the *isfahsalar* Abi [*sic*] al-Fath ibn Muhammad commissioned a soaring *minar*